UNIV 1015: Introduction to Comprenticeship

Course Syllabus | 1.5 Academic Credits | One Semester (15 Weeks)

Course Information

Item	Detail
Course	**UNIV 1015: Introduction to Comprenticeship**
Sponsoring Department	Office of Undergraduate Studies / Center for Community-Engaged Learning (CCEL)
Course Type	Required once before graduation; recommended in the first year
Academic Credits	**1.5 credits** (Half of a standard 3-credit course)
Length	One full semester (15 weeks)
Format	Weekly seminar (1 hr/week) plus a recurring community placement (1.5 hrs/week), in a small group of 2–3 or solo
Seminar Meeting	1 hour per week, Tuesdays, starting January 26, 2027 (Spring 2027 semester); time and room to be set
Community Placement	1.5 hours per week with one designated partner organization (18 hours total)
Enrollment Cap	20 students per section
Group Size	Small groups of 2–3 students recommended for belonging; students may choose to go solo
Faculty Instructor	`[Name, Department, Email, Office Hours]`
Community Partners	Vetted non-profit, civic, and neighborhood partner organizations
Credential Earned	**Comprentice Certification** (Credly /

	Canvas Credentials)
Prerequisites	None; open to all undergraduate majors across all colleges

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Course Description

In this course, you are a **comprentice** (*kom-PREN-tiss*): a student who learns *with* a community, not *for* it.

The word combines the Latin prefix *com-* (together) with *prentice* (the traditional short form of apprentice). Even the Latin root of "community" (*communis*) carries this meaning: *com-* plus *munus*, meaning a **shared gift or duty**.

Traditional university volunteering often treats service as a one-way transaction. **UNIV 1015** reframes this dynamic by treating the **community as the teacher and the student as the apprentice**. Built upon the foundations of Asset-Based Community Development (ABCD) and Critical Service-Learning, this course is grounded in three core commitments:

1. **The community is an expert source of knowledge.**
2. **The relationship is built on a consistent, semester-long weekly routine.**
3. **The final deliverable is co-created and driven entirely by what the partner asks for.**

Guiding principle: start where the community is. Borrowed from social work, this means we do not predict what people need; we work with them to get what they want. Any problem a partner names before the semester is a starting point, which students refine after the listening weeks. Success is measured by whether the community got what it asked for, not by an hour count.

You will spend the semester embedded with one community partner, ideally alongside one or two classmates in a small group of 2–3 so you build belonging with each other as well as with the community. You may also choose to go solo. Each student keeps their own hours, reflections and certification. You will practice listening before taking action, maintain a consistent weekly presence, and conclude by co-creating a project that directly serves your partner's mission. Your partner serves as a co-educator, providing feedback on your growth and presence throughout the semester.

Course Learning Outcomes (CLOs) & Evidence Matrix

By the end of this semester, you will be able to:

Learning Outcome	Measured By / Evidence
1. Differentiate Reciprocal Learning: Explain the difference between one-way transactional service and reciprocal, community-engaged learning.	Weekly Reflection Logs; Final Showcase Story
2. Asset Mapping: Map a community's strengths, cultural assets, history, and people, rather than focusing solely on its deficits.	Community Strengths Map (Week 3)
3. Active Listening: Listen to and learn from community members as teachers and subject-matter experts without imposing unsolicited solutions.	Listening Interview Write-Up (Week 5); Partner Feedback
4. Relational Trust: Keep a consistent weekly commitment and build a trusted, accountable relationship over time.	Verified Attendance Logs; Partner Feedback
5. Co-Creation: Co-create a meaningful deliverable with a community partner based directly on what the partner requests.	Co-Created Partner Project (Weeks 11–14); Partner Feedback
6. Critical Reflection: Reflect on how the community changed your thinking, personal values, civic identity, and sense of belonging.	Weekly Reflection Logs; Final Showcase Story
7. Ethical Storytelling: Articulate the story of your experience honestly with consent, crediting the community's leadership and dignity.	Final Showcase & "What the Community Taught Me" Story

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Weekly Workload Expectation

Based on the institutional and federal standard of approximately 3 hours of academic engagement per credit hour, students should expect **4.5 hours of total work per week** for this 1.5-credit course:

Activity	Hours per Week	Total Semester Hours
Weekly In-Class Seminar	1.0 hour	15.0 hours

On-Site Community Placement	1.5 hours	18.0 hours (+ ~2 hrs orientation)
Reflection Logs, Readings, and Project Co-Design	2.0 – 2.5 hours	~32.5 hours
Total Workload	**~4.5 hours / week**	**67.5 total hours**

Required Readings and Materials

No textbook purchase is required. All readings, case studies, and multimedia resources will be accessible via Canvas. Selected foundational texts include:

- **Robert Sigmon (1979):** *"Service-Learning: Three Principles"*
- **Ivan Illich (1968):** *"To Hell with Good Intentions"*
- **John Kretzmann & John McKnight (1993):** Excerpts from *Building Communities from the Inside Out: A Path Toward Finding and Mobilizing a Community's Assets*
- **Tania D. Mitchell (2008):** *"Traditional vs. Critical Service-Learning: Engaging the Literature to Differentiate Two Models"*
- **Paulo Freire (1968):** Selected excerpts from *Pedagogy of the Oppressed*
- Community-authored reports, histories, and guest lectures provided by community partners.

15-Week Semester Schedule

The semester moves deliberately through four distinct pedagogical phases: **Foundations**, **Listening**, **Practice**, and **Give Back**.

Week	Phase	Seminar Topic	Community Placement Activity	Deliverables Due
1	**Foundations**	**Why "Service" Can Be One-Way:** What comprenticeshi	Meet your matched partner, who is already oriented and	Initial Reflection Log

		p means and reframing community engagement.	expecting your group; use the Canvas as the agenda.	
2	**Foundations**	**Reciprocity in Action:** Learning *with*, not *for*; entering with cultural humility.	Partner site orientation; complete safety onboarding and background checks.	Signed Placement Agreement
3	**Foundations**	**Mapping Strengths:** People, places, history, and Asset-Based Community Development (ABCD).	Guided neighborhood walk; identify community strengths and cultural assets.	**Community Strengths Map (10%)**
4	**Listening**	**The Community as Teacher:** De-centering student expertise and deconstructing assumptions.	First formal partner visit: observe daily routines, shadow staff, and ask open questions.	Reflection Log
5	**Listening**	**How to Listen Without Fixing:** Techniques for non-extractive, empathetic dialogue.	Conduct semi-structured interview with partner staff or community constituent.	**Listening Interview Write-Up (10%)**
6	**Listening**	**Assumptions vs. Reality:** Processing cognitive dissonance and systemic complexity.	Shadow an operational program or direct community interaction.	Reflection Log
7	**Practice**	**Showing Up:** Routine,	Begin recurring weekly	Verified Hours

		reliability, and building longitudinal trust.	placement routine (1.5 hrs on site).	Check-In
8	**Practice**	**Midterm Co-Evaluation:** Checking in on reciprocal value and partner experience.	Regular placement routine; participate in Midterm Partner Check-In.	**Midterm Reflection**
9	**Practice**	**Power, Privilege, and Dignity:** Navigating systemic inequity and the Social Change Wheel.	Weekly placement routine.	Reflection Log
10	**Practice**	**Belonging & Agency:** Becoming a trusted part of a community space.	Routine placement; partner formally names their prioritized project need.	Project Concept Summary
11	**Practice**	**Planning With, Not For:** Co-design methodology and scope management.	Co-plan project timeline and deliverables with site supervisor.	Project Plan Approval
12	**Practice**	**Storytelling with Consent:** Centering privacy, dignity, and asset-based representation.	Routine placement; begin project execution.	Reflection Log
13	**Give Back**	**Project Work Session:** Collaborative problem-solving in the	Dedicated project build session at partner site.	Project Draft / Progress Check

		field.		
14	**Give Back**	**Delivery & Gratitude:** Closing the placement cycle and reviewing outcomes.	Deliver co-created project; receive final partner feedback.	**Co-Created Project (25%)**
15	**Give Back**	**Final Showcase & Storytelling:** Celebrating community co-educators.	Campus symposium: partners attend as honored guests; certification conferral.	**Final Showcase Story (20%)**

Community Partner Principles

Community partners are valued **co-educators** in this course:

- **Partner Readiness (before Week 1):** One to two months before the semester, each partner completes a short orientation and names a real problem it wants help with, as a starting point. Students are matched to that problem by their skills, so a dedicated group of 2–3 arrives expecting it, with the Comprenticeship Canvas as the agenda for the first meeting. Students never cold-email a coordinator who is not expecting them.

- **What Partners Do:** Welcome and orient students, share organizational expertise, identify a meaningful project need, and complete two short co-educator feedback rubrics.

- **What Partners Receive:** Formal recognition as co-educators in university publications and an invitation to the end-of-semester showcase as honored guests.

- **Capacity Limits:** Each partner hosts **2 to 5 students**, usually one or two small groups, ensuring non-profits are never overwhelmed (a 20-student section requires approximately 5–8 partner organizations).

- **Agreements:** Each partner signs the university's standard community partnership agreement before student placement begins.

- **Feedback Privacy & FERPA:** Partners complete evaluations regarding attendance, reliability, and project quality, but final letter grades remain the sole responsibility of the faculty instructor.

Course Tools and Technology

- **Canvas:** Syllabus, readings, reflection submissions, rubrics, grades, and automated certification issuance via Canvas Credentials.
- **Community Engagement Platform:** Any platform the university chooses (for example, Samaky), used for partner sign-up, placement selection, attendance check-in, and hour verification. The comprenticeship method is free for any school to use and is not tied to any company or platform.
- **Co-Curricular Record:** Verified placement hours and the Comprentice certification are automatically added to the student's official co-curricular transcript.
- **Student Data & FERPA:** All digital tools adhere to strict university data-privacy standards.

Course and Institutional Policies

- **Attendance & Reliability:** Community organizations rely on your schedule. Unexcused absences harm community trust. If an emergency occurs, notify your site supervisor and instructor at least 24 hours in advance and arrange a make-up visit.
- **Safety, Background Checks, and Risk Management:** All students must complete site orientations, safety trainings, and background checks required by their placement. Placements adhere to university risk management and off-campus travel regulations.
- **Role Boundaries:** Students work with the mindset of a social worker, not as social workers. Direct support for the people a partner serves stays with the partner's trained staff; students work alongside them, under the partner's guidance.
- **Dignity, Photography, and Privacy:** Never take photos, record audio, or publish social media posts featuring community members without written, informed consent. Protect client confidentiality at all times.
- **Accommodations & Accessibility:** If you require academic or physical site accommodations, notify the instructor and Disability Resources Office early. All site placements can be adapted.
- **Transportation:** Placements are selected based on direct accessibility via public transit, campus shuttles, or walking distance from campus. Transportation equity subsidies (bus passes, rideshare vouchers) are provided.
- **Academic Integrity:** All written submissions and project portfolios must represent the student’s authentic work, properly citing all secondary and community sources.

Enrollment Policy

- **Requirement:** Every student completes one comprenticeship through their university before graduating.

- **Recommended Timing:** Students are encouraged to take UNIV 1015 in their first year. They may take it in a later semester instead, for example once they have chosen a major and want a placement that fits it.

- **Alternative Pathways:** Students who work, commute or have caregiving duties may stay in the course and complete the placement through a campus-based partner project or verified community work they already do.

- **Scaling Rule:** New sections open only when enough partners have agreed to host, so community organizations are never asked to absorb more students than they can teach.

Appendix: Comprentice Certification Specification

Comprentice Certification — Credential & Curriculum Specification

- **Certification Title:** Comprentice Certification: Reciprocal Community Impact
- **Credential Type:** Digital certification, issued in the Open Badges standard
- **Level:** Foundational (Stackable Credential)
- **Issuing Organization:** Center for Community-Engaged Learning (CCEL) & Office of Undergraduate Studies
- **Delivery Format:** In-person weekly seminar (1 hr/week) + on-site community placement (1.5 hrs/week)
- **Estimated Completion Time:** 15 Weeks (~67.5 total workload hours; 18 verified field hours)
- **Prerequisites:** None; open to all undergraduate majors across all colleges
- **Instructor & Co-Educators:** Faculty Instructor & Designated Host Organization Supervisors
- **Version/Date:** Academic Year Pilot (Fall / Spring)

Certification Description

The **Comprentice** certification recognizes a scholar who has demonstrated the capacity to learn *with* a community rather than *for* it. Certification earners practice non-extractive stakeholder listening, apply Asset-Based Community Development (ABCD) methodologies, maintain a consistent and accountable weekly field routine, and co-design a tangible deliverable driven strictly by what the community partner requests.

Purpose

This certification develops practical civic competency, cross-cultural humility, and relational leadership, enabling learners to demonstrate verifiable human skills and ethical community engagement to employers, graduate programs, and civic leadership networks through a verifiable digital credential.

Learning Outcomes for Credentialing

Upon successful completion, certification earners will be able to:

- **Differentiate Reciprocity:** Articulate the critical difference between one-way transactional charity and reciprocal community-engaged learning.

- **Map Community Strengths:** Conduct asset mapping to identify cultural, institutional, and human wealth rather than focusing solely on deficits.
- **Practice Active Listening:** Engage community members as subject-matter experts and co-educators without imposing unsolicited solutions.
- **Cultivate Longitudinal Trust:** Maintain a consistent weekly presence (18 field hours) built on reliability and accountability.
- **Co-Design Deliverables:** Plan, execute, and deliver an authentic project requested directly by a community partner.
- **Apply Ethical Storytelling:** Communicate community narratives with informed consent, dignity, and accurate attribution of community leadership.
- **Reflect Critically:** Evaluate personal assumptions, systemic inequities, civic identity, and institutional belonging.

Certification Modules

Module	Focus	Required Evidence
1. Foundations of Reciprocity	Critical service-learning, cultural humility, and comprenticeship principles	Initial Reflection Log & Placement Agreement
2. Asset-Based Community Development (ABCD)	Identifying neighborhood history, institutions, and community cultural wealth	**Community Strengths Map (10%)**
3. Non-Extractive Listening	De-centering student expertise, asking open questions, shadow observation	**Listening Interview Write-Up (10%)**
4. Relational Practice & Routine	Weekly field consistency, building trust, midterm partner check-in	Midterm Partner Co-Evaluation & Hours Verification
5. Power, Privilege & Social Change	Systemic equity, institutional dynamics, Social Change Wheel	Weekly Reflection Logs (10 entries @ 2% each)
6. Ethical Co-Design	Partner-driven project scoping, feasibility, and collaborative build	Project Scope Summary & Plan Approval

7. Capstone Demonstration	Project delivery and hand-off to community partner	**Co-Created Partner Project (25%)**
8. Reflection & Public Storytelling	Metacognition, dignity in representation, community celebration	**Final Showcase & "What the Community Taught Me" Story (20%)**

Learning Activities

Certification earners complete:

- Weekly faculty-led seminar discussions connecting theoretical texts (Freire, Mitchell, Kretzmann & McKnight, Illich) to field observations.
- Recurring weekly on-site routine (1.5 hours/week) embedded with a single non-profit partner, in a small group of 2–3 or solo.
- Semi-structured stakeholder interviews and neighborhood asset-mapping walks.
- Structured reflection logs analyzing cognitive dissonance, privilege, and ethical engagement.
- Collaborative co-design work sessions with site supervisors and peers.
- Campus-wide Final Showcase presentation co-attended by community partner co-educators.

Required Assessments & Weighting

- **Active Seminar Participation & Reflection Logs:** 20% (10 logs @ 2% each)
- **Community Strengths Map:** 10% (Rubric threshold: ≥ 80% / Proficient)
- **Listening Interview Write-Up:** 10% (Rubric threshold: ≥ 80% / Proficient)
- **Consistency, Attendance & Presence:** 15% (Verified digital check-ins + Partner Midterm/Final check-ins)
- **Co-Created Partner Project:** 25% (Instructor-graded, informed by partner feedback)
- **Final Showcase & Storytelling:** 20% (Rubric threshold: ≥ 80% / Proficient)

Earning Criteria

To earn the **Comprentice Certification**, students must:

1. Complete all 8 curricular modules and 15 seminar meetings.
2. Achieve a final course grade of **B or higher (≥ 80%)** in UNIV 1015.
3. Log and verify at least **18 verified field placement hours** via the check-in system (missed visits can be made up).
4. Receive a satisfactory final co-educator evaluation from the host organization (see Appeals below).
5. Successfully deliver a partner-requested final project.
6. Deliver a consent-based public showcase presentation crediting community co-educators.

Appeals: If a placement ends for reasons outside the student's control, or a student disagrees with a partner evaluation, the student may request a second review. The instructor and CCEL will review the evidence and may arrange a new placement or accept alternate evidence for the certification.

Competency Rubric

Competency	Exemplary (Strong)	Proficient (Developing)	Beginning (Needs Improvement)
Active Listening	Articulates community knowledge in community terms; centers partner wisdom over personal assumptions.	Mentions community perspectives but occasionally reverts to centering student ideas.	Centers exclusively on student actions; ignores or misinterprets partner voice.
Reciprocity	Demonstrates clear mutual benefit; articulates how both student and partner contributed and gained.	Acknowledges exchange but frames interactions with slight paternalism.	Frames the experience strictly as "helping," "fixing," or charity work.
Critical Reflection	Synthesizes field experiences with course readings (Freire, Mitchell, Kretzmann); documents changed thinking.	Describes site experiences accurately with moderate conceptual analysis.	Merely summarizes activities and events without critical reflection or conceptual framing.

Dignity & Ethics	Consistently applies consent-based storytelling; uses asset-based, respectful framing.	Generally respectful with minor, unintentional reliance on deficit-based phrasing.	Uses deficit language or shares partner stories/images without informed consent.

Evidence Requirements & Final Portfolio

The final credential portfolio submitted via Canvas must contain:

- Signed Community Placement & Safety Agreement.
- Completed Community Strengths Map.
- Listening Interview Transcript / Write-Up.
- Verified field attendance logs (18 hours).
- Complete Co-Created Project deliverable and written partner sign-off.
- Final Reflective Showcase Story ("What the Community Taught Me").

Certification Metadata (Open Badges Standard)

- **Certification Name:** Comprentice Certification: Reciprocal Community Impact
- **Description:** Demonstrates foundational competency in Asset-Based Community Development (ABCD), non-extractive stakeholder listening, sustained relational accountability (18 verified field hours), ethical co-design, and dignity-centered community storytelling.
- **Skills:** Community-Engaged Learning, Asset-Based Community Development (ABCD), Stakeholder Listening, Cultural Humility, Relational Leadership, Ethical Storytelling, Project Co-Design, Civic Engagement.
- **Earning Criteria:** Completion of all 8 course modules, verified placement attendance, partner-endorsed project delivery, and achievement of a grade of B or higher in UNIV 1015.
- **Issuing Body:** Center for Community-Engaged Learning (CCEL) & Office of Undergraduate Studies.
- **Verification Method:** 1-Click public verification link via Canvas Credentials / Credly, verifiable on LinkedIn and logged on the official University Co-Curricular Record.